military, which operates parallel to the regular army. The IRGC also controls the state's range of nonconventional capabilities, as well as in the Basij militias, fringe groups of ruthless hoodlums who, for a minimal fee, are prepared to serve the government in any mission; they are often used to suppress any signs of opposition to it.

There is an inherent contradiction between Iranian pride based on Iran's Aryan origins and imperial past, and the pride of a Shiite sharia state that believes in the vision of the world caliphate. As I have already mentioned, I tend to believe that the Khomeini revolution in 1979 gave primacy to Shiite Islam as an Iranian value but at the same time was motivated by the imperial legacy of the past. The refined Iranian vision is, therefore, to bring back the glory days of the empire in the form of the future Islamic caliphate.

The Iranian Conundrum

This section begins with a picture of the "nuclearizing" Iran of 2010 and updates it through events leading up to 2018, the time of this book's writing. I thought it useful to include earlier assessments in order to provide the reader with a window into the thinking and analysis of senior intelligence officials whose job it is to advise the political leaders, in whose hands lies the responsibility of making fateful decisions.

Anyone hoping for a lecture according to linear logic is likely to be disappointed. I have written a collection of insights, working assumptions, rumors, and, most of all, dilemmas and ponderings; at the time of writing, I had not yet formulated a clear and consistent opinion. What is more, things were, and remain to this day, in a constant state of fluidity.

The section is laid out as follows:

1. A description of Iran's domestic situation as of 2010.
2. A description of what was happening in the halls of government in Washington during Obama's administration. In my assessment, the bottom line was that the United States would not attack Iran and would accept a one- to two-year breakout time.